

ANDROID ARRIVES!

India finally has an Android phone—HTC Magic. But what does Android mean for cellphone users in the country? We take a closer look

■ NIMISH DUBEY

Google's much-hyped operating system (OS) Android has been in the news for a while now. Recently, it made its presence in India official when HTC launched HTC Magic, the first phone in India running Android. While this represented a major event for the tech crowd, many mainstream users were unmoved. After all, information about mobile OS remains relatively limited in the Indian market, where phones are sold more on technical specifications (camera's megapixel count, storage space, size of the display and so on) rather than the software running on them. But there are indications that the coming months will see Android-driven devices from Samsung and Motorola as well. This will allow many more users to access features like high-quality Internet browsing, push mail, online chatting and the like that most people associate with higher-end devices.

What is Android?

An operating system developed for mobile devices, Android is based on open Linux kernel.

It has been designed in such a manner that it can allow developers to create applications that can make the most of all the features a

handset can offer. This is because unlike other mobile platforms, Android treats third-party applications on the same level as core applications that are an integral part of the operating system. This may pave the way for some of the most powerful applications that can be made for a mobile phone—from office suites to browsers to e-mail clients—as there are no restrictions on the developers.

Free of cost

Android can well change the entire smartphone market in India. It is available totally free of cost to anyone who wants to use it. A person can change it and use it as per his needs. If that does not seem special, just consider the amount of money cellphone manufacturers using Android will save as they will not need to invest in developing an OS or pay the likes of Microsoft or Nokia for the use of their OS.

As Vinay Goel, country head, Google, highlights, "It is not because the OS is free, the fact that as a phone handset manufacturer, I do not have to necessarily write the device drivers for every component on my phone—they are all open source. So I save a lot on development costs. I do not have to go out and create a developer eco-system for this phone—it comes for free."

In real terms, that would cut a significant amount off the software costs of the phone. Goel feels that the ideal cost for an Android-driven cellphone would be somewhere between Rs 10,000 and Rs 15,000—a space generally occupied by low-end smartphones in the country. Imagine getting a powerful cellphone for that price rather than a relatively mod-



HTC Magic Android-powered device